

Creamed almond spinach and tofu

Indian-style is a wonderful way to prepare spinach, with chunks of tasty tofu instead of the traditional paneer, or homemade cheese. Paneer, also spelled panir, is a simple, unripened cheese, not unlike farmer's cheese. It's used in Indian dishes, often as an essential protein source. If you're vegan or serving one, here's your opportunity to shine with your alternative to dairy. The dish looks beautiful spooned over rice. Serve with Indian flatbread, potatoes, and a salad.

6 garlic cloves, minced

1 tablespoon nutritional yeast

1 teaspoon curry powder

1 tablespoon brown rice vinegar

2 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

3½ tablespoons olive oil

¼ cup vegetable oil [60ml]

1 pound extra-firm tofu, pressed to remove excess water and sliced horizontally in half [500g]

Salt

1 small onion, chopped

1 tablespoon minced fresh ginger

1 fresh serrano or jalapeño pepper, minced

½ teaspoon black mustard seeds

1 teaspoon turmeric powder

1 teaspoon crushed coriander seed

1 bunch of fresh spinach (about 10 to 12 ounces), thoroughly washed, tough stems removed [300 to 350g]

½ cup almond milk [125ml]

1. **Mix** 3 cloves of the garlic with the nutritional yeast, curry powder, vinegar, and 1 tablespoon each sugar and olive oil in a large bowl. Set the marinade aside.
2. Heat the vegetable oil in a large cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. When the oil is very hot and almost shimmering, **fry** the tofu, turning once, until lightly browned and crisp on both sides, 2 to 3 minutes. Drain on paper towels and season lightly with salt. Pour out excess oil from the pan and set pan aside.

3. As soon as the tofu is cool enough to handle, **cut** it into cubes and add to the marinade. Toss until very well coated.
4. In a separate large sauté pan, **heat** 1½ tablespoons of the olive oil over medium heat. Add the onion and cook until soft and translucent, 3 to 5 minutes. Add the remaining garlic, the ginger, and serrano pepper and cook for another minute or so, stirring constantly. Add the mustard seeds, turmeric, coriander, and ½ teaspoon salt and continue to cook for another 30 seconds, or until the spices are very fragrant.
5. **Add** half of the spinach to the pan. Raise the heat to medium-high. As soon as the spinach wilts and there is room, add the rest to the pan. Cook, stirring often, until all the spinach is reduced and is soft and tender, about 3 minutes.
6. Scrape the spinach mixture into a food processor and **blend** with the almond milk until smooth and creamy. Pour back into the pan and stir in the remaining 1 tablespoon each olive oil and sugar. Remove from the heat.
7. Heat the cast-iron skillet over high heat. **Pour** the tofu with all its marinade into the skillet. (Use a rubber spatula to scrape all the marinade out of bowl.) Cook, stirring constantly, until the marinade is completely absorbed and the tofu is well coated, about 1 to 2 minutes. Let the tofu cool slightly, then add to the spinach and stir well. Simmer over low heat for 5 minutes.

SERVES 2